

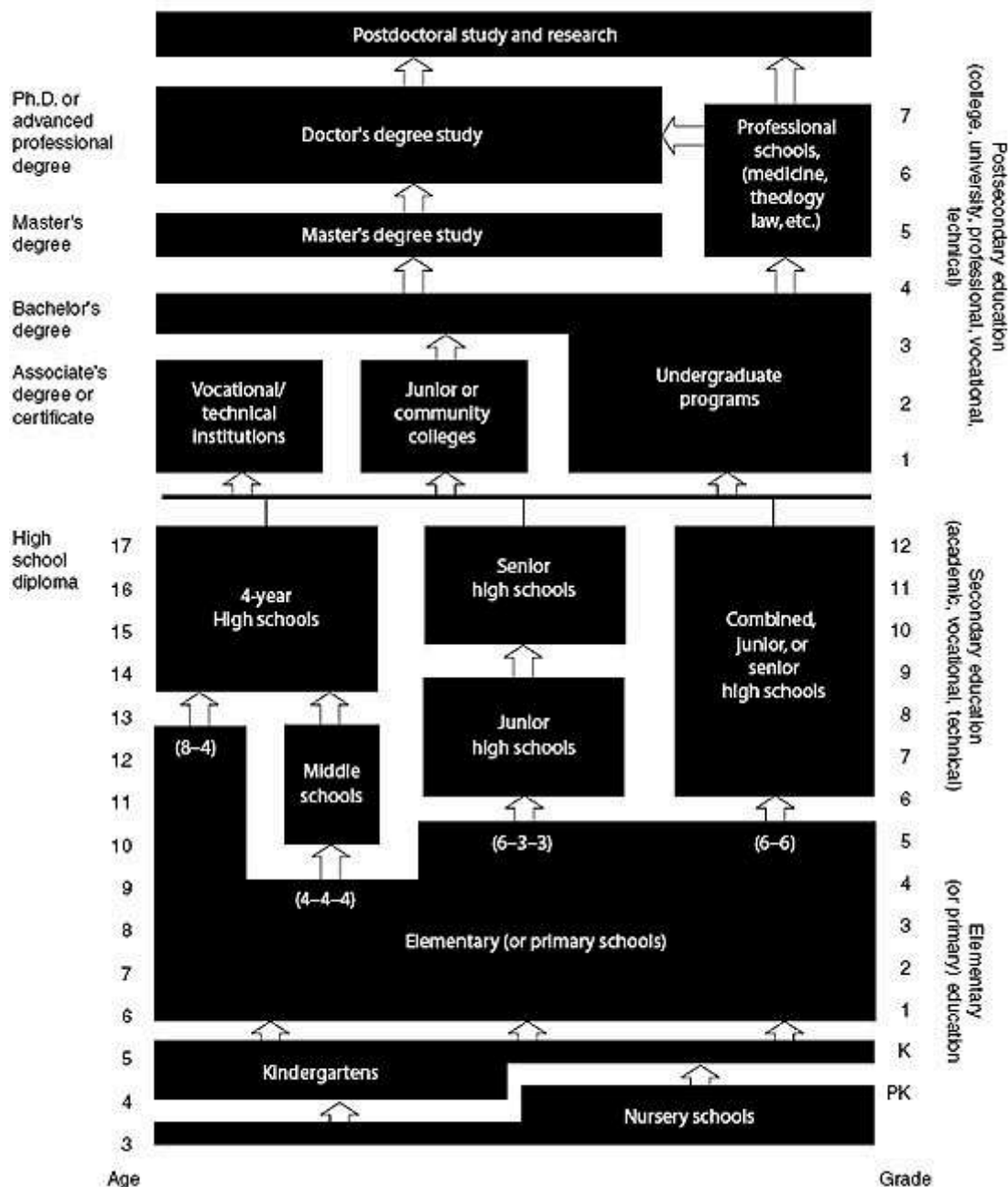
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2.1 The Structure of the US Education System

Focus Questions:

- *How old are most students when they enter a US kindergarten school?*
- *What are the types of degrees offered at colleges and universities?*
- *What are some of the questions international students should ask when deciding which program and school to study at in the US?*
- *What is the difference between an associate degree and a four-year degree?*

The US education system may be organized very differently from the system in the home countries of international students. Reflected in a chart, it looks like this, complete with pathways between levels:



Pre-School and Kindergarten

American students begin either in preschool or kindergarten for one to three years before progressing to elementary (primary) school. In most states, the age at which a child must start school is six.

Most school districts offer a free year of kindergarten before the starting year; in most cases, children must be five years of age to enter kindergarten. If you are counseling a family planning to have a child under the age of six attending school in the US, make sure to ask the kindergarten schools under consideration about their cut-off birth dates for turning five, as this varies by school district.

Elementary (Primary) and High School (Secondary School)

Children attend elementary (primary) school for varying amounts of time. In most cases, they attend elementary until Grade 6. They then progress to one of the following: a junior high school for two years, a combined junior/senior high school (generally Grades 7–12), or a four-year high school. Please note that high schools can also be called secondary schools.

School-aged students in the US have the option of going to public schools (free) or to private schools (where they must pay tuition or be on scholarship). The vast majority (88%) attend public schools; nation-wide, 9% attend private schools, but this percentage is much higher in some regions and cities, and among Caucasian Americans. Three percent are home-schooled, in which case parents and/or caregivers provide education to children provided their practices meet the education laws of the state.

International students tend to attend K–12 private schools at a much higher rate than public schools, especially because public high school schools allow international students to study for only one year. Private schools have no such limit.

Graduating High School

There is no federally set national examination determining whether a student has successfully graduated high school in the US. However, as of this writing, 25 states require that students take a high-school exit examination for graduation, and three additional states have legislation that will see such exams required in the future.

Whether or not a national examination is used in assessment, American high schools issue high-school diplomas to students who have completed their curriculum.

As we have discussed, because different states and school districts determine what is taught in schools and how, the courses that must be completed to earn a high-school diploma will vary from one school and state to another.

American students normally graduate high school at age 17 or 18.

Post-secondary Options

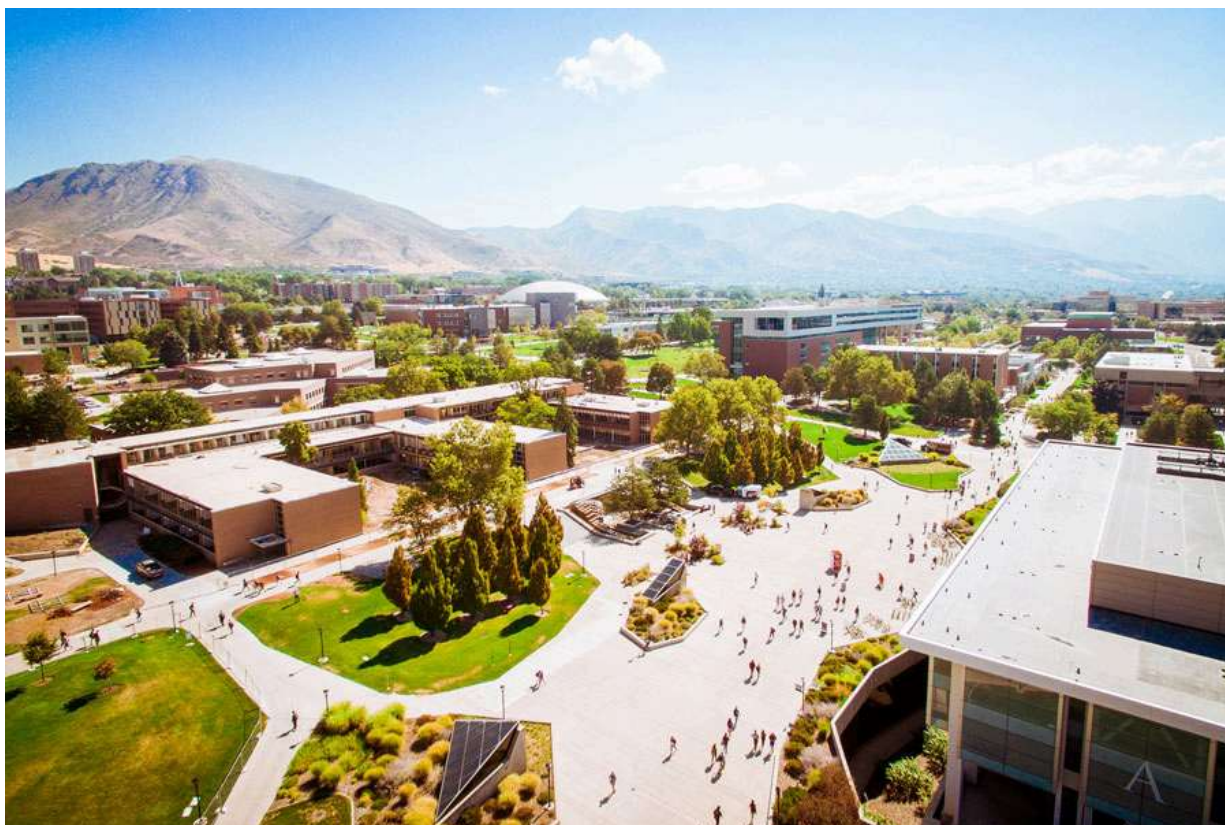
The US offers a wide variety of higher education options for the diverse requirements and goals of domestic and international students. This variety encompasses:

- Types of institutions (e.g., private vs. public, academic vs. vocational, etc.)
- Length of programs (e.g., one year, two years, four years, etc.)
- Levels (e.g., associate, bachelor's, master's, post-graduate)
- Types of credential (e.g., non-degree, degree, micro-credential)
- Delivery models (e.g., online, hybrid, in-person)
- Tuition fees (from very affordable to extremely expensive)
- Location of institutions (e.g., urban vs. rural, west vs. east, etc.)

The **US government notes** that there are currently:

- 124,000 public and private schools in the US;
- Over 2,000 postsecondary non-degree career and technical schools (CTE);
- Over 4,000 degree-granting institutions of higher education.

They explain: "Of the higher education institutions, over 1,600 award associate degrees and some 2,400 award bachelor's or higher degrees. Over 400 higher education institutions award research doctorates."



Flexibility in the System

International students may decide to begin at one type of institution (for example, a community college) and then move to another institution or level. Many higher education institutions have agreements that allow students to transfer credits achieved at a two-year institution to a degree program at a four-year institution. Students who choose to “mix and match” their study programs often do so because it can be more affordable.

Important note for agents: Not all two-year programs lead seamlessly (through transfer credits) to four-year institutions. It is important to ask if there are agreements in place for international students interested in this kind of progression.

Is there a difference between a “college” and a “university”?

In the US, the terms “college” and “university” often – but not always – refer to the same kind of higher education institution (HEI), and as pathway provider **Shorelight** points out:

“Some are even called institutes (e.g., Massachusetts Institute of Technology, California Institute of Technology). Within larger universities in the United States, there are different colleges or schools that represent different academic areas of study (e.g., College of Engineering, School of Business).”

WENR concurs but adds a bit more clarification on characteristics a “university” must have but that a “college” may or may not offer:

“There are no nationally standardized definitions of “university” or “college,” and the name of an institution alone may not indicate exactly what type of institution it is. That said, **a university, at minimum, offers bachelor’s programs and at least some master’s programs.**”

The term “university” may also indicate that an HEI is relatively more research-intensive (e.g., with more postgraduate degrees) than other types of post-secondary education.

Types of College/University

One way of understanding post-secondary options in the US is to look at how they are funded.

Public universities (also known as State universities) receive at least some of their funding from the state government. Many belong to a **state university system**, which is a larger group of public universities spread throughout a US state that are connected in some ways through administrative functions but that operate separately from each other. Examples are **State University of New York** (SUNY), **City University of New York** (CUNY), and **University of California** (UC).

Community colleges are also supported by public funding, and they mainly specialize in offering two-year degree programs (associate degrees).

Private universities receive most of their revenue through students’ tuition fees, which are often higher than those charged by public universities. These institutions are often highly ranked and with very selective admissions requirements, include Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), Harvard, and Yale. For more examples, [please click here](#).

Liberal arts colleges offer mostly (though not exclusively) undergraduate courses focus on teaching undergraduate-level courses in the liberal arts

and sciences (although some also offer graduate-level programs and more vocational subjects such as medicine, business administration or law).

For-profit private universities and colleges. Unlike other types of university, for-profits operate as business ventures, aiming to make money for their shareholders as well as providing a good education for their students.

Carnegie Classification System

A useful tool for understanding the different types of higher education institution (HEI) that international students can attend in the US is the Carnegie Classification System:

- Doctoral universities: HEIs that awarded at least 20 research/scholarship degrees in the past year that are not professional practice doctoral-level degrees (such as the JD, MD, or PharmD).
- Master's colleges and universities: HEIs that awarded at least 50 master's-level degrees and fewer than 20 doctoral degrees during the past year.
- Baccalaureate colleges: HEIs where at least 50% of degrees were awarded in the past year at the bachelor's level or higher, comprising fewer than 50 master's degrees or 20 doctoral degrees. In other words, bachelor's degrees are these institutions' primary focus.
- Baccalaureate/associate's colleges: HEIs that mostly award associate degrees but that also have at least one baccalaureate (four-year) degree program. Associate degrees must make up at least 50% of all degrees awarded in the past year.
- Associate's colleges: HEIs at which the associate degree is the highest level of degree awarded to students.
- Special focus institutions: Institutions where a single field or set of fields (e.g., music, art) dominate the focus of the institution and degrees awarded are linked to this field. These include
- Faith-Related Institutions, Medical Schools & Centers, Other Health Professions Schools, Engineering Schools, Other Technology-Related Schools, Business & Management Schools, Arts, Music & Design Schools, and Law Schools. For more on such institutions, [please click here](#).

- Tribal colleges: International students are not eligible to attend these colleges because they are reserved for Native (Indigenous) Americans.

As well as understanding the Carnegie Classification System, agents should also know that there are many excellent vocational programs in the US delivered through Career and Technical Education (CTE) schools and community colleges. This is increasingly important because research shows that there is **growing interest among students across the world in shorter, practical programs.**

Five Important Facts About the Post-Secondary System In the US

- There are both public and private colleges/universities in the US. Most of these are operated by the states and territories.
- As noted earlier in this section, “college” and “university” are often used interchangeably, but *they sometimes do mean different things to different people*. For example, a university can sometimes indicate a more research-oriented orientation than a college, and sometimes universities are broken down into different “colleges,” whereby “college” indicates a unit or sub-section of the university. Still, it is important that agents research a college/university thoroughly to understand its educational approach and range of programs, as the word “college” or “university” in a name does not always mean the same thing.
- *Top-notch higher education institutions in the US come in all shapes, sizes, and types*. Successful alumni graduate from community colleges, liberal arts colleges, research-oriented universities, public and private institutions – not just the most elite, Ivy-League schools. Excellent programs can be found across the country.
- *Quality assurance and accreditation* for institutions and programs in the US is carried out by private, non-governmental organizations. The US Department of Education provides oversight of these accrediting organizations. There are 19 recognized organizations that provide regional or national accreditation for institutions, and 60 that provide accreditation for individual programs. To obtain an F-1 visa, students must enrol in an accredited institution. Agents must make sure that an institution and program is accredited before recommending it to

students for the purposes of quality control. For more on why this is, and for The Council of Education (CHEA) database providing information about over 8,200 institutions and over 44,000 programs in the US, please click here. [<https://www.chea.org/about-accreditation>]

- Each HEI will have different admissions practices. Generally, shorter degree programs and certificates have lower admission standards: some even offer “open admissions” in an effort to be as inclusive to every type of student as possible. However, as the need for professional and technical skills grows in economies across the world, there are increasingly more competitive admissions policies for in-demand fields such as engineering, nursing, and other healthcare fields.
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